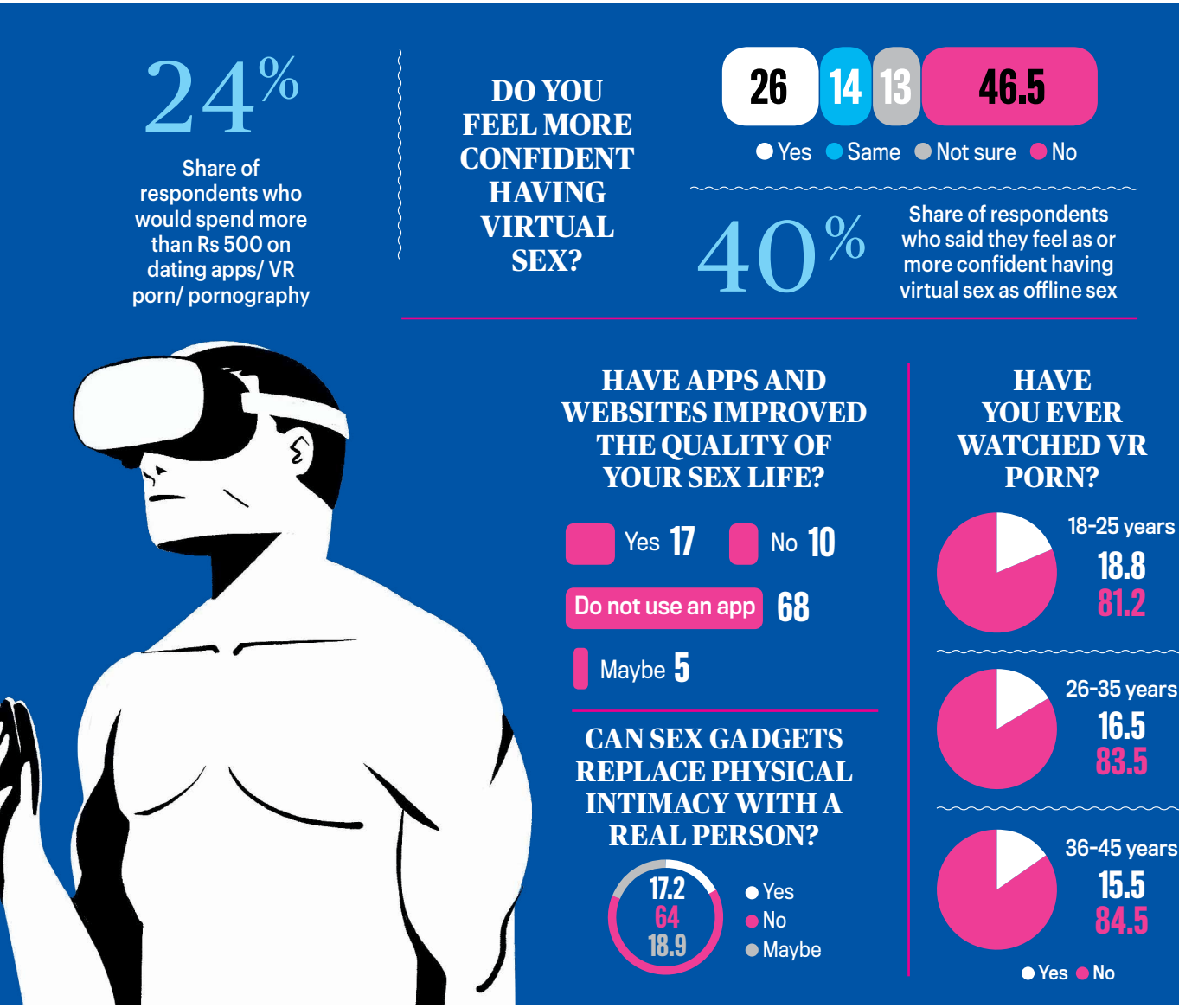
Graphics by TANMOY CHAKRABORTY; *Illustration by* SIDDHANT JUMDE



Some websites also let you sync with devices such as Fleshlight, giving both the digital experience of being on screen and the offline experience of sexual touch. In fact, 19 per cent of those between 18 and 25 years of age who participated in the INDIA TODAY sex survey said they have tried VR porn.

However, despite these advances, conversations around sexual pleasure remain hushed. Most people still wouldn't comfortably admit to using sex toys—the survey found that most men (61 per cent) and women (63 per cent) would not tell their friends that they use sex toys, and a majority (54 per cent men and 57 per cent women) wouldn't even date someone who uses them.

EMOTIONS STILL RULE

Beyond this sea change, however, what remains important is the need for emotional intimacy. There is more to the dating game than just casual sex. "Texting and video telephony are how my generation communicates. To us, it is a perfectly natural way to get to know someone. Even when I hadn't met my partner, I still cared greatly for her," says 34-year-old Aditya Agarwal from Noida, an IT executive who met his wife on a dating app. The survey results also indicate that you don't have to physically meet someone before developing feelings for them, underlining what Mumbai-based clinical sexologist Dr Prakash Kothari also says—that even virtual partners can get attached to one another, seeking progressive, meaningful and long-term relationships. Around 43 per cent of the respondents in the survey said that virtual sex may lead to a long-term relationship, and 58 per cent said that they might feel bad if a virtual sex partner 'ghosted' them, that is, vanished without an explanation or goodbye.

Technology has thus drastically transformed the way Indians have sex or try to find intimacy. Sex is still as much an emotional need as a physical one, but the real—and much-needed—shift is the focus on understanding the self. And while stigma and questions around sexual pleasure remain, behind closed doors, things certainly are changing. One step at a time. ■